PERSUASION by Jane Austen
(A2–A2+)

INTRODUCTION

Ss read an extract from *Persuasion* by Jane Austen in which Captain Wentworth asks Anne Elliot to marry him and she says no because her friend Lady Russell has persuaded her that she should wait for someone more suitable. Ss talk about what makes a story romantic and find out about the average marriage age in other countries.

Supplementary Materials

WARM UP: bring a picture of an engagement ring in a box. **Active Investigation Ex 3:** internet access OR find and print copies of synopses from the internet for *Romeo and Juliet, Captain Corelli's Mandolin, Wuthering Heights, Titanic* and *Twilight*.
Alternatively you could add to the synopses in the Answer Key in this section and print these off for Ss. Have enough copies of each one so that everyone who chooses that story can have a copy.

CLIL CONNECTION Ex 5: internet access

WARM UP

Suggestion 1: Show the class the picture of the box with the engagement ring inside. Ask *What is this ring for?* (It's for asking someone to marry you.)

Suggestion 2: If both you and the class are comfortable with mime and acting, start the class by miming a proposal to someone on bended knee. (Propose to an imaginary suitor rather than putting a student on the spot!) You can show by your reaction to their answer what the imaginary suitor has said. Then ask the Ss to tell you what happened.

After the warm up above ask Ss *Who usually proposed marriage in the early 19th century – the man or the woman? What reasons might make the 19th century woman accept or refuse a proposal?*

Allow them a few minutes to come up with answers to the second question and then feedback as a class. If you wish, you can extend the discussion to compare with the difference with the modern world, e.g. women can propose although it's not traditional, marriage is not only for men and women in some countries, etc.

Culture notes

Jane Austen
Jane Austen was born in 1775 in the Hampshire countryside in England. She started writing as a teenager and her books were very popular with both readers and critics. Each of her novels, which were written in the early part of the nineteenth century, can genuinely be described as a literary masterpiece. The theme of marriage and 'finding a husband' runs throughout her books.

Austen received several proposals of marriage, but rejected each of them in turn. She fell in love with a young man who felt the same way about her, but as both of them were penniless, they weren't allowed to marry. Many critics have wondered if this real-life experience inspired the story behind *Persuasion*. The book was published one year after her death at age 41.

During Austen's time, girls were considered old enough to marry at a very young age compared with modern England. Age 16–19 would not have been strange.

Persuasion
Anne Elliot meets Captain Frederick Wentworth again, seven years after she turned down his marriage proposal. Both single, the story follows the fortunes of Anne's family and the various relationships among the young people. She realises Wentworth is still angry with her but that she has feelings for him. Eventually they declare their feelings and marry.

PREPARATION

THINKING ROUTINE

1

see

Focus Ss on the picture of the wedding rings and ask the class the two questions: *What do these rings mean? What are they usually made of?*

ANSWERS:
1 A marriage
2 Gold, silver or platinum, usually

think

Put Ss into pairs or small groups and allow time for them to discuss each question. Monitor and help with vocabulary as needed. In feedback, gather ideas as a class but no answers are 'correct'. Ask Ss to make a notes of their answers for Question 4 to come back to later.

PHOTOCOPIABLE © Pearson Education Limited 2022

wonder

Arrange Ss into pairs or small groups and allow time for them to discuss each question. Monitor and help them with vocabulary as needed. In feedback, gather ideas as a class but no answers are 'correct'.

READING PREVIEW

Focus Ss on the title and write on the board *He asked her to marry him*. Cross out the last four words and ask Ss if they know another way to finish the sentence so it means the same thing. Write on the board any answers Ss give and tell them they will discover a new way to say it after reading the text. If Ss come up with the correct answer (for her hand) do not confirm it at this stage.

READING EXTRACT LL4.01

Tell Ss they're going to read an extract from *Persuasion* by Jane Austen, written in the early 19th century. Give Ss time to read the text in silence, or play the recording as Ss read. When they have finished, ask them if they now know how to finish the sentence. (*He asked for her hand.*)

Write the four characters' names on the board: *Sir Walter, Captain Wentworth, Anne Elliot, Lady Russell*. Ask Ss to make notes on what each character does in the story. Ss compare their notes with a partner.

Whole class. Elicit the events of the story onto the board until the main events are reconstructed. Every single detail does not have to be included in the reconstruction.

Alternative approach

For **stronger classes**, write the characters' names on the board: *Sir Walter, Captain Wentworth, Anne Elliot, Lady Russell*. Ask Ss to listen and make notes on what each character does in the story then play the recording with books closed. Ss compare their notes with a partner. Play the recording again for Ss to add to their notes. With their partner, Ss reconstruct the story and then they can open their books and read the extract to check they have understood. When they have finished, ask them if they now know how to finish the sentence. (*He asked for her hand.*)

COMPREHENSION

2 **Focus Ss on the question sentences 1–10 and the names in the box. Tell them they can use the names more than once. Allow time for them to complete the sentences individually. Check answers as a whole class.**

ANSWERS:

1 Captain Wentworth **2** Sir Walter **3** Lady Russell
4 Captain Wentworth **5** Lady Russell **6** Anne Elliot
7 Anne Elliot **8** Anne Elliot **9** Anne Elliot
10 Captain Wentworth

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION

3 **Elicit Ss' ideas of what ingredients make a film or story romantic and write the ideas on the board. Then focus on the story titles in the box and ask if they already know any of the stories. Ask them what a synopsis is (a summary of a story). Then ask them to choose one of the stories in the box.**

Tell Ss they're going to find out what happens to the two people by reading a synopsis or using their own knowledge of the story and decide whether or not the story is romantic according to their ideas. Ss will need internet access if they are doing the research themselves, or you can assign the research for homework. Alternatively, give each student a copy of the relevant synopsis you have brought (see Supplementary materials) and allow them time to underline the key details. Monitor and help them with the language where necessary.

Ask *Which stories have a happy ending?* Ask Ss if a happy or sad ending is more romantic, again referring back to their ideas above.

SPEAKING

4 **When Ss are clear on the main details of their story, divide them into pairs or small groups with people who worked on a different story. Ss tell each other the main events from the synopsis they have read. Then ask them to decide in their group, or hold a vote for the whole class, which story is the most romantic.**

ANSWERS:

Romeo and Juliet: Their families are enemies and say they can't be together. It's not a happy ending because they both kill themselves. *Captain Corelli's Mandolin*: Captain Corelli is Italian and Pelagia is Greek and they're on opposite sides in WW2. When the Italians change sides, the Germans kill many of them, and Corelli escapes. Pelagia is left on the island. When he comes back later he sees her with a child and thinks she has married so they never get back together – a sad ending. But they are together again when they're very old, so that could be seen as a happy ending.

Wuthering Heights: Heathcliff and Cathy are kept apart essentially by social class, but also by their own stubborn pride. A sad ending as Cathy dies and Heathcliff is a bitter, angry man who can only think of revenge.

Titanic: Jack dies in the cold sea after the ship sinks, so they can't be together. A sad ending!

Twilight: It takes a long time for Edward and Bella to be together because he's a vampire and she's human but they marry in the second film/book, so it's a happy ending.

PHOTOCOPIABLE © Pearson Education Limited 2022

Ask if Ss if they think the extract they read from *Persuasion* is romantic or not. Ask them to give a reason for their answer.

Teaching tip

Encourage Ss to link back to their own previous thoughts and ideas to see if/how their thinking evolves after new input. In this case, whether they think *Persuasion* is romantic or not may be connected to their ideas in Ex 2 Question 7, where they discus what happens when someone can't marry the person they want to marry.

CLIL CONNECTION

Geography

5 A Elicit countries from the whole class onto the board, under the headings *The Americas, Europe, Asia,* etc. Ask Ss to make a list of ten of the countries in a table in their notebooks and to guess the age people get married in each one and write it next to the country.

Country	My guess	Average age
Spain	32	

Alternative approach

Arrange Ss in teams and have each team line up in front of the board. Give the first student in each line a pen to write one country on the board and then pass the pen back. Call out categories, e.g. *The Americas, Europe, Asia,* and they can only write countries for that category until you call the next one. Stop when you have about 20 countries on the board.

B Ss research online to find out the average age people marry in each country. Then they compare their answers with their guesses and write the answer in the third column in their table.

C Put Ss back into the pair or small groups they worked in for the Thinking Routine activities. Ask them to discuss how these average ages compare with their ideas about a good age to marry. Ask *Have you changed your mind?*

Homework idea

- Ss write an ending for the extract from *Persuasion*. It should be in keeping with a romance, whether happy or sad.

PHOTOCOPIABLE © Pearson Education Limited 2022